CHINAR MEHTA

Postdoctoral Researcher
Faculty of Arts and Social Sciences
Maastricht University, NL

Research Interests: Feminist Science and Technology Studies, Digital Cultural Studies, Infrastructure Studies, Digital Public Infrastructure

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ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Oct '26 – present	**Postdoctoral Researcher,** **Maastricht University Faculty of Arts and Social Sciences** Working with the Hype Studies Network - a transdisciplinary research arena that investigates how hype influences economic trends, political agendas, media narratives, and technological developments. Course coordinator for DSO1002 Digitalization and Politics
July '25 – Oct '26	**Assistant Professor,** **International Institute of Information Technology, Bangalore** Courses taught to Bachelor of Technology students in Computer Science and Artificial Intelligence. More details about the courses can be found on my website here. 1. Foundational Science and Technology Studies (core) (90 & 121 students in two classes) 2. User Research using Qualitative Methods (elective) (21 students) 3. Gender, Technology, Society (elective) (30 students) **Student mentorship** I was on the doctoral committee of the following students: Aparna Sharma, PhD candidate, IIIT Bangalore, 2025 – present. Kanchan Kaur, PhD candidate, IIIT Bangalore, 2025 – present. Abhiraj Bibhar, PhD candidate, SRM University-AP, 2026 – present. I supervise the following MS by Research students: Eddie Kapou, MS by Research, IIIT Bangalore, 2025 – present. Wise Agbogan, MS by Research, IIIT Bangalore, 2025 – present.

Feb ‘25 – Feb ‘26 (1y)	**Research Consultant, Digital Futures for Children, London School of Economics & Political Science and 5Rights** The project studies the use and experiences of teenagers in 4 countries regarding Generative Artificial Intelligence.
Jan ’23 – Sept ’23 (9m)	**Fulbright Fellow, Human-Computer Interaction Institute, Carnegie Mellon University, Pittsburgh, PA, US** Received a 9-month fellowship to be mentored by Dr. Sarah Fox. Actively a part of the Future of Transit Work project.
Jan ‘20 – Dec ’22 (2y)	**Research Lead, Feminist Approaches to Labour Collectives** FemLab.co is a seed-funded initiative by the International Development Research Center (IDRC), Canada, as part of their Future of Work series. This initiative does grassroots research on how women workers can strengthen their position in the global supply chain and labour markets using digital platforms.

EDUCATION

Aug ‘19 – May ‘25	**Ph.D. in Communication, Department of Communication, University of Hyderabad, Hyderabad** PhD thesis looks at web development cultures from a Feminist Science & Technology Studies perspective; through historical discourse, in-depth interviews with engineers, managers, designers, and archival & software documentation.
Jun ‘17 - May ‘19	**Master of Arts in Media and Cultural Studies,** **Tata Institute of Social Sciences, Mumbai** Research Advisor: Prof Shilpa Phadke
Jul ‘11 - May ‘15	**Bachelor of Technology in Information and Communication Technology, DA-IICT, Gandhinagar**

GRANTS & FELLOWSHIPS

Travel grant to present at the Association of Internet Researchers Annual Conference in Sheffield, UK. 29 October – 3 November 2024. ~$1,500.

Fulbright-Nehru Doctoral Fellowship, United States-India Educational Fund, US Department of State. January 2023 – September 2023. ~$16,000.

Travel grant to present at the International Communication Association Annual Conference: One world, One Network? in Paris, France. 26 May - 30 May 2022. ~$1,500.

Junior & Senior Research Fellowship, University Grants Commission of India. August 2019 – July 2024. ~$32,000 over 5 years.

Travel grant to present at Imagine a Feminist Internet: Research, Practice, and Policy in South Asia Conference, Negombo, Sri Lanka. 21-23 February 2019. ~$800.

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

- (Under Review) Mehta, C., Fox, S. E., & Vaghela, P. (2025). Solving for "Bad Workers": How Socio-Technical Imaginaries of Caste, Labor, and Datafication Normalize Unjust Tracking of Sanitation Workers. *Computational Culture*.
- Akridge, H., Fan, B., Tang, A. X., **Mehta, C.**, Martelaro, N., & Fox, S. E. (2024). "The bus is nothing without us": Making Visible the Labor of Bus Operators amid the Ongoing Push Towards Transit Automation. *Proceedings of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, 1–16. Link.
- Mehta, C., & Gupta, A. (2024). The Pundits of Technology: The Construction of Masculine Authority in Socio-technical Projects. *Subversions: A Journal of Emerging Research in Media & Cultural Studies*, *8*. Link.
- (Submitted) D'Souza, S., Gupta, S., **Mehta, C**., Arora, P., & Raman, U. (n.d.). Workshop as Methodology in Action Research. *Design Issues*.

BOOK CHAPTERS

- Mehta, C., Raman, U., & Arora, P. (2024). A Feminist Human–Machine Communication Framework: Collectivizing by design for inclusive work futures. In A. Guzman, R. McEwen, & S. Jones (Eds.), *The SAGE Handbook of Human–Machine Communication*. SAGE Publications. Link.
- Mehta, C. (2023). What Lies in the Shadows of a Stakeholder Analysis? A Methodological Analysis to Contextualize the Lives of Women Workers in the Global South. In P. Arora, U. Raman, & R. König, *Feminist Futures of Work: Reimagining Labour in the Digital Economy*. Amsterdam University Press. Link.

MANUSCRIPTS IN PREPARATION

Meritorious Boy Technologist: Analysing the Caste-gender axis in Science and Technology Studies. This paper has to do with how myths of merit and instinct serve to naturalize caste and gender advantage in software engineering education and professionalization.

Visions of Technocratic Development: Exploring historical moments of technooptimism in Computing in India. This paper examines how specific moments in the Indian history of computing contributed to technooptimistic and technosolutionistic perceptions in governance.

REPORTS

Kasturi, S., Mehta, C., & Raman, U. (2025). *RIGHTS.AI: Children's experiences of generative artificial intelligence in India* [Report]. Digital Futures for Children centre, 5Rights Foundation. Link.

Mehta, C., Raman, U., & Arora, P. (2023). *Digitalisation and Transformations of Women's Labour in Sanitation Work* (Empowerment or Exploitation? Global Perspectives on Women's Work in the Platform Economy) [Edition 5]. Just Jobs Network. Link.

Mehta, C., Bansal, P., & Koenig, R. (2021). *Connecting the Informal: Stakeholder mapping of women's informal work in India and Bangladesh*. FemLabCo. Link.

SELECTED PRESENTATIONS

(Upcoming) *Rock as Solid-Fluid: Exploring Urbanities Through Rocks in Hyderabad, India*. European Association for the Study of Science and Technology, October 2026, Krakow, Poland.

(Upcoming) *Constructing the Citizen-Resident: Analysing the Infrastructuring of the Togolese e-ID* (with Eddie Kapou). European Association for the Study of Science and Technology, October 2026, Krakow, Poland.

(Upcoming) *Constructing Identity: Analyzing Legal and Policy Discourse of the Togolese e-ID* (with Eddie Kapou). Society for Social Studies of Science, October 2026.

Kapou, E., & Mehta, C. (2026, March 5). *Beaches Brew: Entanglements of Coastal Economies and Urban Life in Lomé, Togo*. An International Conference (Hybrid) on Urban/Media Infrastructures.

Kaur, K., Mehta, C., & Prakash, A. (2026, February 15). *In and Beyond the Newsroom How Journalism and Fact-Checking Practices Stabilise Facts in India*. Making and Unmaking Facts Conference 2026.

Solving for "Bad Workers": How Imaginaries Normalize Surveillance of Workers in the panel "Constructing the Digital: Working from the Global South" at the Association of Internet Researchers Annual Conference held between 29 October – 3 November 2024 in Sheffield, UK.

"Collectives" in the panel "Interfacing with Informality: A Decolonial Feminist Labour Lexicon" at International Communication Association Annual Conference: One World, One Network? held between 26 May - 30 May 2022 in Paris, France.

Web Standards and Protocols: Identifying Transnational Actors & Networks. 7 October 2021. Society for Social Studies of Science (4S) Annual Meeting 2021.

WORKSHOPS CONDUCTED

The Shadow of Software: Developing an STS Toolkit to Study Code. Winter School, STS India 2025, IIT Delhi, Sonepat, December 13, 2025.

Collaborative Explorations in Feminist STS: Provocations and Possibilities (with Anushree Gupta and L. Krishnakumar). Winter School, STS India 2025, IIT Delhi, Sonepat, December 14, 2025.

INVITED WORKSHOPS

Feminist Futures Now. 19 – 21 August 2024 in Goa, India. Organized by Digital Futures Lab and American Jewish World Service.

Invited Participant, International Doctoral Institute, Center for Advanced Research in Global Communication, University of Pennsylvania. March 2024.

Interface as Knowledge-in-practice: A Feminist Analysis of Web Development in India. 4 October 2021. Doctoral Colloquium, Association of Internet Researchers Annual Meeting 2021.

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Sub-theme coordinator, "Interrogating Digital Selves and Subjectivities," Indian Association of Women's Studies Conference, January 2027, Christ University, Bengaluru (upcoming).

Coordinator, Digital STS Reading Group and Feminist STS Reading Group, STS India Network (present).

Session Chair, "Women and Technology" panel, STS India Network Conference, December 2025.

Organizer, Association of Internet Researchers Flashpoint Symposium, Hyderabad, April 2024. *Constructing the Digital: Working from the Global South*.

Organizer, Association of Internet Researchers Satellite Event, Hyderabad, October 2021. *Interfacing, Interacting, Internetting in Pandemic Times*.

Organizer, 71st Annual International Communication Association Conference, Hyderabad Hub, May–June 2021. *Engaging the Essential Work of Care: Communication, Connectedness, and Social Justice*.

Organizer, *Bodily Habitations*, Seminar held by Department of Communication, University of Hyderabad, March 2020.

LANGUAGES: English (professional), Hindi (bilingual), Gujarati (native)